

Question ID aa5897b8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: aa5897b8

In Jane Austen’s novel *Mansfield Park*, an almost imperceptible smile from potential suitor Henry Crawford causes the protagonist Fanny Price to blush; her embarrassment grows when she suspects that he is aware of it. This moment—in which Fanny not only infers Henry’s mental state through his gestures, but also infers that *he* is drawing inferences about *her* mental state—illustrates what literary scholar George Butte calls “deep intersubjectivity,” a technique for representing interactions between consciousnesses through which Austen’s novels derive much of their social and psychological drama.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- It states a claim about Austen’s skill at representing psychological complexity that is reinforced by an example presented

A. in the following sentence.
- It advances an interpretation of an Austen protagonist who is contrasted with protagonists from other Austen novels

B. cited in the following sentence.
- It describes a recurring theme in Austen’s novels that is the focus of a literary scholar’s analysis summarized in the

C. following sentence.
- It provides a synopsis of an interaction in an Austen novel that illustrates a literary concept discussed in the following

D. sentence.

ID: aa5897b8 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The underlined sentence provides a concrete example to ground readers’ understanding of the “deep intersubjectivity” described in the next sentence as central to Austen’s work.

Choice A is incorrect. There is no evaluation made of Austen’s skill in this sentence, and no examples are given in the following sentence. This choice essentially flips the paragraph: it’s this first sentence that provides an example. Choice B is incorrect. There are no other Austen protagonists mentioned in this passage, so this couldn’t be the answer. Choice C is incorrect. The underlined sentence doesn’t identify any “recurring theme,” but instead simply describes one interaction from one book. This interaction exemplifies the literary technique of “deep intersubjectivity” that is introduced in the next sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 54804e10

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 54804e10

While scholars believe many Mesoamerican cities influenced each other, direct evidence of such influence is difficult to ascertain. However, recent excavations in a sector of Tikal (Guatemala) unearthed a citadel that shows _____ Teotihuacán (Mexico) architecture—including a near replica of a famed Teotihuacán temple—providing tangible evidence of outside influence in portions of Tikal.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. refinements of
- B. precursors of
- C. commonalities with
- D. animosities toward

ID: 54804e10 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of architectural influences among Mesoamerican cities. In this context, “commonalities with” means similarities to or shared attributes with. The text indicates that a recently discovered citadel in Tikal includes a close imitation of a famous temple in Teotihuacán (another Mesoamerican city) and other evidence of Teotihuacán influence, which suggests that the citadel possesses features that resemble architectural features found in Teotihuacán. This context thus indicates that the Tikal citadel shows commonalities with Teotihuacán architecture.

Choice A is incorrect because there’s nothing in the text that suggests that the Tikal citadel shows “refinements of,” or improvements on, Teotihuacán architecture. Although the text suggests that the architecture of Teotihuacán influenced the architecture of the Tikal citadel, and although it’s possible that later architectural designs could make improvements on earlier designs, the text doesn’t discuss whether, in imitating Teotihuacán architecture, the Tikal citadel’s builders improved on it. Choice B is incorrect because describing the citadel in Tikal as showing “precursors of” Teotihuacán architecture—or features that preceded and foreshadowed those of Teotihuacán architecture—would imply the opposite of what the text suggests about the relationship between the architecture found in Tikal and Teotihuacán. The text claims that the discovery of similarities between the Tikal citadel and the architecture of Teotihuacán, including a replica of a temple in Teotihuacán, provides evidence of outside influences on Tikal architecture. If the Tikal citadel was influenced by Teotihuacán architecture, then the Teotihuacán architecture must predate the citadel, not the other way around. In this context, therefore, it wouldn’t make sense to say that the Tikal citadel shows precursors of Teotihuacán architecture. Choice D is incorrect because the text discusses how the citadel in Tikal indicates the influence of Teotihuacán architecture, which implies that the makers of the Tikal citadel likely admired aspects of Teotihuacán architecture enough to imitate it. Thus, there’s no reason to think that the Tikal citadel provides evidence of the Tikal people’s “animosities toward,” or feelings of strong dislike or hostility toward, Teotihuacán architecture.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b4887dae

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: b4887dae

Mathematician Claude Shannon is widely regarded as a foundational figure in information theory. His most important paper, “A Mathematical Theory of Communication,” published in 1948 when he was employed at Bell Labs, utilized a concept called a “binary digit” (shortened to “bit”) to measure the amount of information in any signal and determine the fastest rate at which information could be transmitted while still being reliably decipherable. Robert Gallagher, one of Shannon’s colleagues, said that the bit was “[Shannon’s] discovery, and from it the whole communications revolution has sprung.”

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- It presents a theoretical concept, illustrates how the name of the concept has changed, and shows how the name has entered common usage.

A. entered common usage.
- It introduces a respected researcher, describes an aspect of his work, and suggests why the work is historically significant.

B. significant.
- It names the company where an important mathematician worked, details the mathematician’s career at the company, and provides an example of the recognition he received there.

C. and provides an example of the recognition he received there.
- D. It mentions a paper, offers a summary of the paper’s findings, and presents a researcher’s commentary on the paper.

ID: b4887dae Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text starts with a general statement that introduces Shannon, then describes a specific contribution from one of his papers, then provides a quote that illustrates just how important this contribution was.

Choice A is incorrect. This isn’t the overall structure. The text only mentions very briefly, in parentheses, that “binary digit” was shortened to “bit.” It doesn’t go into detail about this name change, and it doesn’t discuss any “common usage” of the name at all. Choice C is incorrect. This isn’t the overall structure. Shannon’s employment at Bell Labs is only mentioned once, very briefly: the text never goes into detail about his career there, and it never mentions any recognition he received there. Choice D is incorrect. This is too narrow. Overall, the text is about Shannon’s importance in his field, not just this one paper of his.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f3c45b4f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	■ ■ ■

ID: f3c45b4f

Text 1

Fossils of the hominin *Australopithecus africanus* have been found in the Sterkfontein Caves of South Africa, but assigning an age to the fossils is challenging because of the unreliability of dating methods in this context. The geology of Sterkfontein has caused soil layers from different periods to mix, impeding stratigraphic dating, and dates cannot be reliably imputed from those of nearby animal bones since the bones may have been relocated by flooding.

Text 2

Archaeologists used new cosmogenic nuclide dating techniques to reevaluate the ages of *A. africanus* fossils found in the Sterkfontein Caves. This technique involves analyzing the cosmogenic nucleotides in the breccia—the matrix of rock fragments immediately surrounding the fossils. The researchers assert that this approach avoids the potential for misdating associated with assigning ages based on Sterkfontein’s soil layers or animal bones.

Based on the texts, how would the researchers in Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined portion in Text 1?

- They would emphasize the fact that the *A. africanus* fossils found in the Sterkfontein Caves may have been corrupted in
A. some way over the years.
- They would contend that if analyses of surrounding layers and bones in the Sterkfontein Caves were combined, then the
B. dating of the fossils there would be more accurate.
- They would argue that their techniques are better suited than other methods to the unique challenges posed by the
C. Sterkfontein Caves.
- They would claim that cosmogenic nuclide dating is reliable in the context of the Sterkfontein Caves because it is applied
D. to the fossils directly.

ID: f3c45b4f Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. Text 2 states that the researchers used cosmogenic nuclide dating to "avoid the potential for misdating" caused by the geology of Sterkfontein, which Text 1 describes as "challenging" and unreliable.

Choice A is incorrect. Neither text suggests that the *A. africanus* fossils have been "corrupted," but only that traditional dating methods are difficult in Sterkfontein because of floods and soil mixing where the fossils were found. Nothing is implied to have compromised the fossils themselves. Choice B is incorrect. This choice misreads Text 2. Text 2 agrees that stratigraphy and other methods are prone to error in the context of Sterkfontein: there’s a "potential for misdating" when evaluating age based on soil layers and bones. Choice D is incorrect. Text 2 does not state that cosmogenic nuclide dating is applied to the fossils directly but rather to the breccia that surrounds them.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f7c02e89

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: f7c02e89

Text 1

Films and television shows commonly include a long list of credits naming the people involved in a production. Credit sequences may not be exciting, but they generally ensure that everyone’s contributions are duly acknowledged. Because they are highly standardized, film and television credits are also valuable to anyone researching the careers of pioneering cast and crew members who have worked in the mediums.

Text 2

Video game scholars face a major challenge in the industry’s failure to consistently credit the artists, designers, and other contributors involved in making video games. Without a reliable record of which people worked on which games, questions about the medium’s development can be difficult to answer, and the accomplishments of all but its best-known innovators can be difficult to trace.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to the discussion in Text 2?

- By recommending that the scholars mentioned in Text 2 consider employing the methods regularly used by film and television researchers
- By pointing out that credits have a different intended purpose in film and television than in the medium addressed by the scholars mentioned in Text 2
- By suggesting that the scholars mentioned in Text 2 rely more heavily on credits as a source of information than film and television researchers do
- By observing that a widespread practice in film and television largely prevents the kind of problem faced by the scholars mentioned in Text 2

ID: f7c02e89 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 1 would most likely respond to Text 2 based on the information provided. Text 2 discusses how the inconsistent use of credits to identify the contributors to video games can pose an obstacle to scholars of the medium, who rely on such credits to answer questions about the medium's development. Text 1 notes that in film and television, on the other hand, credits are used consistently and are valuable to researchers studying the cast and crew members in these mediums. Since Text 1 asserts how the consistent use of credits benefits scholars of film and television, it can be inferred that this text's author would respond to the discussion in Text 2 by observing that the kind of problem faced by scholars of video games—the inability to know who contributed to a particular production and how—is, in film and television studies, largely prevented by the widespread practice of credits in these mediums.

Choice A is incorrect. Although Text 1 discusses a method used by film and television researchers—namely, relying on credits to research the careers of cast and crew members—the author doesn't explicitly recommend that or any other method. Moreover, Text 1 states that films and television shows themselves, not their researchers, regularly use the method of listing credits. Choice B is incorrect. It can be inferred from Text 2 that when video games do feature credits, they have essentially the same function as credits in film and television—namely, to identify the individuals who worked on a particular production. Therefore, it is unlikely that the author of Text 1 would characterize video game credits as differing in purpose from film and television credits. Choice C is incorrect because, as Text 2 explains, credits are not consistently used in video games. Therefore, it is unlikely that the author of Text 1 would argue that scholars of the medium discussed in this text—video games—rely more heavily on credits than scholars of film and television, two mediums where credits consistently appear.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c14daa3c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: c14daa3c

Close analysis of the painting *Girl with a Flute*, long attributed to the seventeenth-century Dutch painter Johannes Vermeer, has revealed subtle deviations from the artist’s signature techniques. These variations suggest that the work may be that of a student under Vermeer’s tutelage—potentially _____ our understanding of Vermeer as a solitary artist.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. negating
- B. prefiguring
- C. entrenching
- D. substantiating

ID: c14daa3c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. "Negating" means "reversing" or "making invalid." Proving that Vermeer worked with students would reverse the view of him as a solitary artist.

Choice B is incorrect. "Prefiguring" means "being an early indicator of." There already existed views of Vermeer as a solitary painter, so a new painting would not be an early indicator of those views. Rather, a painting proving that Vermeer had a student would contradict those earlier views. Choice C is incorrect. "Entrenching" means "solidifying." A painting proving that Vermeer had a student would not solidify views of him as solitary, but would rather contradict those views. Choice D is incorrect. "Substantiating" means "supporting with proof." A painting proving that Vermeer had a student would not support views of him as solitary, but would rather contradict those views.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3566120b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3566120b

The following text is adapted from Oscar Wilde’s 1895 play *The Importance of Being Earnest*. CECILY: Have we got to part?
ALGERNON: I am afraid so. It’s a very painful parting.
CECILY: It is always painful to part from people whom one has known for a very brief space of time. The absence of old friends one can endure with equanimity. But even a momentary separation from anyone to whom one has just been introduced is almost unbearable.

As used in the text, what does the word “endure” most nearly mean?

- A. Regret
- B. Persist
- C. Tolerate
- D. Encourage

ID: 3566120b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because as used in the text, “endure” most nearly means tolerate. In the text, Cecily and Algernon discuss parting, or saying goodbye. Cecily remarks on the deep pain of saying goodbye to people whom one has only known briefly and then comments on the equanimity, or calm steadiness, one experiences when separated from old friends. The text sets up an ironic contrast: one can easily tolerate, or put up with, the absence of close friends, but even a very short separation from a new acquaintance is unbearable.

Choice A is incorrect. Nothing in the text suggests that Cecily associates regret, or a feeling of sorrow, with the absence of old friends. Rather, the text sets up an ironic contrast between the feeling of calm steadiness one feels when separated from old friends and the unbearable pain of being separated from new acquaintances. Choice B is incorrect. Although in some contexts “endure” can mean persist, or proceed stubbornly, it doesn’t have that meaning in this context because what is being endured is the absence of old friends. Whereas one can persist *despite* the absence of someone else, one can’t persist the absence itself. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t convey that Cecily encourages, or urges, old friends to be absent. Although it may be that Cecily prefers new acquaintances to friends she has known for a long time, the text focuses on her feelings as a result of others’ absences, not on her treatment of others.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 34d7bb25

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 34d7bb25

According to Indian economist and sociologist Radhakamal Mukerjee (1889–1968), the Eurocentric concepts that informed early twentieth-century social scientific methods—for example, the idea that all social relations are reducible to struggles between individuals—had little relevance for India. Making the social sciences more responsive to Indians’ needs, Mukerjee argued, required constructing analytical categories informed by India’s cultural and ecological circumstances. Mukerjee thus proposed the communalist “Indian village” as the ideal model on which to base Indian economic and social policy.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- The text recounts Mukerjee’s early training in the social scientific disciplines and then lists social policies whose

A. implementation Mukerjee oversaw.
- The text mentions some of Mukerjee’s economic theories and then traces their impact on other Indian social scientists of

B. the twentieth century.
- The text presents Mukerjee’s critique of the social sciences and then provides an example of his attempts to address

C. issues he identified in his critique.
- The text explains an influential economic theory and then demonstrates how that theory was more important to

D. Mukerjee’s work than other social scientists have acknowledged.

ID: 34d7bb25 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The text does indeed present Mukerjee’s critique of the social sciences—that they were too Eurocentric—and then provides an example of how he attempted to address the issues he identified: by suggesting a social science model based on the Indian village.

Choice A is incorrect. The text doesn’t discuss Mukerjee’s early training or his oversight of the implementation of social policies at all. Choice B is incorrect. The text never discusses any other Indian social scientists. Choice D is incorrect. The text never mentions other social scientists’ responses to Mukerjee’s work.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a60b0004

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: a60b0004

Scholarly discussions of gender in Shakespeare’s comedies often celebrate the rebellion of the playwright’s characters against the rigid expectations _____ by Elizabethan society. Most of the comedies end in marriage, with characters returning to their socially dictated gender roles after previously defying them, but there are some notable exceptions.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. interjected
- B. committed
- C. illustrated
- D. prescribed

ID: a60b0004 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of gender roles in Shakespeare’s comedies. As used in this context, “prescribed” would mean laid down as rules. The text indicates that the characters in the comedies often defy gender roles that are “socially dictated” (even if most characters do return to those roles eventually) and that scholars have been very interested in these acts of defiance. This context indicates that what the characters are rebelling against are standards of behavior prescribed by the society of the time.

Choice A is incorrect because saying that expectations about gender were “interjected,” or suddenly inserted between other things, wouldn’t make sense in context. There’s no suggestion in the text that the issue of gender roles was inserted between other things or was an interruption in a larger discussion. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that Shakespeare depicts characters rebelling against expectations about gender that have been “socially dictated,” not expectations that society has “committed,” or carried out, entrusted, or promised. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that Shakespeare depicts characters rebelling against expectations about gender that have been “socially dictated,” not expectations that have been “illustrated,” or clarified with examples. Although it’s possible for expectations about gender roles to be illustrated, there’s nothing in the text to indicate that characters in Shakespeare’s comedies rebel against illustrations of gender expectations.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e4e2aeb3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: e4e2aeb3

Text 1

Like the work of Ralph Ellison before her, Toni Morrison’s novels feature scenes in which characters deliver sermons of such length and verbal dexterity that for a time, the text exchanges the formal parameters of fiction for those of oral literature. Given the many other echoes of Ellison in Morrison’s novels, both in structure and prose style, these scenes suggest Ellison’s direct influence on Morrison.

Text 2

In their destabilizing effect on literary form, the sermons in Morrison’s works recall those in Ellison’s. Yet literature by Black Americans abounds in moments where interpolated speech erodes the division between oral and written forms that literature in English has traditionally observed. Morrison’s use of the sermon is attributable not only to the influence of Ellison but also to a community-wide strategy of resistance to externally imposed literary conventions.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely characterize the underlined claim in Text 1?

- As failing to consider Ellison’s and Morrison’s equivalent uses of the sermon within the wider cultural context in which

A. they wrote
- B. As misunderstanding the function of sermons in novels by Black American writers other than Ellison and Morrison
- C. As disregarding points of structural and stylistic divergence between the works of Ellison and those of Morrison
- As being indebted to the tradition of resisting literary conventions that privilege written forms, such as novels, over

D. sermons and other oral forms

ID: e4e2aeb3 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The author of Text 2 argues that Morrison’s use of the sermon is not only influenced by Ellison, but also by a “community-wide strategy of resistance” to literary conventions practiced by Black American authors. Ellison, Text 2 alleges, is only one of many influences on Morrison.

Choice B is incorrect. Neither text specifically mentions sermons in works by authors other than Morrison or Ellison, only a tendency towards eroding “the division between oral and written forms” among Black American writers. Choice C is incorrect. Both texts describe similarities between the works of Ellison and Morrison, and neither points out instances of divergence. Text 2 simply suggests that Morrison was influenced by more than just Ellison. Choice D is incorrect. While Text 2 does discuss Morrison’s resistance to certain literary conventions, it’s unclear what it would mean for the underlined claim to be “indebted” to that tradition. This choice recycles language from the text, but not in a way that makes any coherent point.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6a1dc7c5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 6a1dc7c5

Text 1

Virginia Woolf’s 1928 novel *Orlando* is an oddity within her body of work. Her other major novels consist mainly of scenes of everyday life and describe their characters’ interior states in great detail, whereas *Orlando* propels itself through a series of fantastical events and considers its characters’ psychology more superficially. Woolf herself sometimes regarded the novel as a minor work, even admitting once that she “began it as a joke.”

Text 2

Like Woolf’s other great novels, *Orlando* portrays how people’s memories inform their experience of the present. Like those works, it examines how people navigate social interactions shaped by gender and social class. Though it is lighter in tone—more entertaining, even—this literary “joke” nonetheless engages seriously with the themes that motivated the four or five other novels by Woolf that have achieved the status of literary classics.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the assessment of *Orlando* presented in Text 1?

- By conceding that Woolf’s talents were best suited to serious novels but asserting that the humor in *Orlando* is often

A. effective
- By agreeing that *Orlando* is less impressive than certain other novels by Woolf but arguing that it should still be regarded

B. as a classic
- By acknowledging that *Orlando* clearly differs from Woolf’s other major novels but insisting on its centrality to her body of

C. work nonetheless
- By concurring that the reputation of *Orlando* as a minor work has led readers to overlook this novel but maintaining that

D. the reputation is unearned

ID: 6a1dc7c5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the assessment of *Orlando* in Text 1. Both authors agree that *Orlando* is unusual for Woolf: Text 1 states that the novel examines its characters' psychologies more superficially than Woolf's other novels do, and Text 2 describes it as being lighter in tone. However, while Text 1 calls *Orlando* an "oddity" and mentions that Woolf "began it as a joke," Text 2 asserts that *Orlando* engages the same themes as Woolf's other great novels. Hence, the author of Text 2 would most likely accept that *Orlando* differs from Woolf's other novels but would also insist on its importance in the context of Woolf's work as a writer.

Choice A is incorrect. Text 2 does suggest that the humor in *Orlando* is effective. However, there's nothing in Text 2 to suggest that the author would agree that Woolf's talents were best suited to serious novels. Rather, the author of Text 2 compares *Orlando* favorably to other novels by Woolf that are implied to be darker in tone. Choice B is incorrect because the author of Text 2 does not indicate that *Orlando* is less impressive than Woolf's other novels, but instead points out that it engages the same themes as other novels by Woolf that are considered classics. Choice D is incorrect because there's nothing in Text 1 or Text 2 to suggest that readers have generally ignored *Orlando* because of its reputation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5dce6cab

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 5dce6cab

Given that the conditions in binary star systems should make planetary formation nearly impossible, it’s not surprising that the existence of planets in such systems has lacked _____ explanation. Roman Rafikov and Kedron Silsbee shed light on the subject when they used modeling to determine a complex set of factors that could support planets’ development.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. a discernible
- B. a straightforward
- C. an inconclusive
- D. an unbiased

ID: 5dce6cab Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s description of efforts to explain the existence of planets in binary star systems. As used in this context, describing an explanation as “a straightforward” one would mean that the explanation is direct and uncomplicated. The text asserts that since it should be “nearly impossible” for planets to form in binary star systems, it’s “not surprising” that there isn’t a straightforward explanation for the existence of planets in such systems; the fact that one potential approach involves “complex” factors offers further contextual support for this idea.

Choice A is incorrect because it would not make sense in context to say that there isn’t “a discernible” explanation—meaning an explanation capable of being perceived—for the existence of planets in binary star systems. The text discusses just such an explanation offered by Roman Rafikov and Kedron Silsbee, which indicates that their explanation can be discerned. Choice C is incorrect because the text emphasizes how difficult it is to explain the existence of planets in binary star systems, suggesting that the situation isn’t marked by the lack of “an inconclusive” explanation—an explanation that does not resolve the issue—but rather that if any explanations have been offered, they’ve likely been inconclusive ones. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that there is a lack of “an unbiased,” or impartial and unprejudiced, explanation for the existence of planets in binary star systems. The text indicates that it’s difficult to explain the existence of planets in such systems and it describes one attempt to do so, but there is no evidence that explanations from Roman Rafikov and Kedron Silsbee or others are biased.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e4f312c5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: e4f312c5

While most animals are incapable of passing somatic mutations—genetic alterations that arise in an organism’s nonreproductive cells—on to their offspring, elkhorn coral (*Acropora palmata*) presents an intriguing ____: in a 2022 study, researchers found that elkhorn coral produced offspring that inherited somatic mutations from a parent.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. hypothesis
- B. affinity
- C. anomaly
- D. corroboration

ID: e4f312c5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. An "anomaly" is something that deviates from norms or expectations. In this case, the elkhorn coral is an anomaly because it can pass on somatic mutations, whereas most other animals can't.

Choice A is incorrect. A "hypothesis" is "a theory about something," but no theories are provided about elkhorn coral in this text, just facts. Choice B is incorrect. "Affinity" represents "an inclination or liking toward something." As genetic mutations tend to occur without any conscious effort, you can't really have an inclination toward passing on somatic mutations. Choice D is incorrect. "Corroboration" means "evidence to support or prove something." Because elkhorn coral do the opposite of what most animals do, they do not provide corroboration of the theory that somatic mutations can't be passed onto offspring. Rather, they show the opposite.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4eee64fa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	■ ■ ■

ID: 4eee64fa

Space scientists Anna-Lisa Paul, Stephen M. Elardo, and Robert Ferl planted seeds of *Arabidopsis thaliana* in samples of lunar regolith—the surface material of the Moon—and, serving as a control group, in terrestrial soil. They found that while all the seeds germinated, the roots of the regolith-grown plants were stunted compared with those in the control group. Moreover, unlike the plants in the control group, the regolith-grown plants exhibited red pigmentation, reduced leaf size, and inhibited growth rates—indicators of stress that were corroborated by postharvest molecular analysis.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- It describes an experiment that addressed an unresolved question about the extent to which lunar regolith resembles A. terrestrial soils.
- B. It compares two distinct methods of assessing indicators of stress in plants grown in a simulated lunar environment.
- C. It presents evidence in support of the hypothesis that seed germination in lunar habitats is an unattainable goal.
- D. It discusses the findings of a study that evaluated the effects of exposing a plant species to lunar soil conditions.

ID: 4eee64fa Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The text describes an experiment wherein space scientists compared plant growth in terrestrial and lunar soil conditions. It then discusses the findings of the study, including the fact that all the seeds germinated but that the plants grown in lunar soil exhibited signs of stress.

Choice A is incorrect. The text doesn't address this question, and never describes any specific characteristics of either soil. It merely describes the outcome of an experiment that exposed a plant species to lunar soil conditions. Choice B is incorrect. The text never compares methods of assessing indicators of stress—instead, it simply mentions several stress indicators observed in the study (red pigmentation, reduced leaf size, and inhibited growth rates). Choice C is incorrect. The text doesn't present any evidence that we could never achieve seed germination in lunar habitats, and in fact states that the seeds in the lunar soil did germinate.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a70cbc53

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: a70cbc53

Raymond Antrobus, an accomplished poet and writer of prose, recently released his debut spoken word poetry album, *The First Time I Wore Hearing Aids*, in collaboration with producer Ian Brennan. The album contains both autobiographical and reflective pieces combining Antrobus’s spoken words with Brennan’s fragmented audio elements and pieces of music to convey how people who are deaf may experience sound, both its presence and absence. Some critics suggest that the album questions the function of sound in the world, highlighting that the experience of sound is multifaceted.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- It introduces a collaborative spoken word poetry project, details the approach taken to produce the work, and then

A. provides an example of critique the album received upon release.
- It mentions a collection of spoken word poems, distinguishes one poem as being an exemplar on the album, and then

B. offers a summary of the subject matter of the whole collection.
- It summarizes the efforts to produce a collection of spoken word poems, presents biographies of two people who

C. worked on the album, and speculates about the meaning behind the poetry.
- It connects two artists to the same spoken word poetry project, explains the extent of their collaboration on each poem,

D. and then provides an overview of the technique used to produce the work.

ID: a70cbc53 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The text first introduces the album as being a collaboration between Antrobus and Brennan, then describes the approach taken to produce it, then mentions how critics have said that it calls into question the function of sound.

Choice B is incorrect. While the text does mention a collection of spoken word poems, it doesn’t single out one poem as being particularly noteworthy. Additionally, the text doesn’t simply summarize the subject matter—it goes into detail about the content and production of the album. Choice C is incorrect. The text doesn’t provide biographical information about the two artists, and the text doesn’t speculate about the meaning behind the poetry—instead, it relays what some critics have said about the album. Choice D is incorrect. The text doesn’t provide just an overview of the production techniques used but instead goes into more detail about the content and audio elements of the album, as well as critical response to the album.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 37e5c794

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 37e5c794

Despite being cheap, versatile, and easy to produce, _____ they are made from nonrenewable petroleum, and most do not biodegrade in landfills.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. there are two problems associated with commercial plastics:
- B. two problems are associated with commercial plastics:
- C. commercial plastics’ two associated problems are that
- D. commercial plastics have two associated problems:

ID: 37e5c794 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice ensures that the modifying phrase “despite being cheap, versatile, and easy to produce” appears immediately before the noun it modifies, “commercial plastics,” clearly establishing that the commercial plastics—and not another noun in the sentence—are being described as cheap, versatile, and easy to produce.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the function word “there” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that “there” is cheap, versatile, and easy to produce. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “two problems” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “problems” are cheap, versatile, and easy to produce. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “commercial plastics’ two associated problems” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “problems” are cheap, versatile, and easy to produce.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f0864217

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: f0864217

Rabinal Achí is a precolonial Maya dance drama performed annually in Rabinal, a town in the Guatemalan highlands. Based on events that occurred when Rabinal was a city-state ruled by a king, _____ had once been an ally of the king but was later captured while leading an invading force against him.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. *Rabinal Achí* tells the story of K'iche' Achí, a military leader who
- B. K'iche' Achí, the military leader in the story of *Rabinal Achí*,
- C. the military leader whose story is told in *Rabinal Achí*, K'iche' Achí,
- D. there was a military leader, K'iche' Achí, who in *Rabinal Achí*

ID: f0864217 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma.

Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma. Choice D is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ea0aa676

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: ea0aa676

In the 1970s, Janaki Ammal, a prominent botanist, emerged as a powerful voice in India’s environmental conservation movement. Her exhaustive chromosomal survey of plants in Silent Valley, a pristine tropical forest in Kerala, India, that is home to nearly 1,000 species of native flora (many of which are endangered), _____ instrumental in the government’s decision to preserve the forest.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are
- B. were
- C. have been
- D. was

ID: ea0aa676 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The subject "survey" is singular, and so is the verb "was."

Choice A is incorrect. The subject "survey" is singular, but the verb "are" is plural. Choice B is incorrect. The subject "survey" is singular, but the verb "were" is plural. Choice C is incorrect. The subject "survey" is singular, but the verb "have been" is plural.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fba5d8d1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: fba5d8d1

In a 2016 study, Eastern Washington University psychologist Amani El-Alayli found that, among the study participants who experienced frisson (a physiological response akin to goosebumps or getting the chills) while listening to music, there was one personality trait that they scored particularly _____ openness to experience.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. high. On
- B. high on;
- C. high on
- D. high on:

ID: fba5d8d1 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between the main clause ("there...on") and the supplementary phrase ("openness to experience") and to introduce the information that identifies which personality trait participants scored especially high on.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "on" and separates a necessary preposition from the clause beginning with "there." Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join the main clause ("there...on") and the supplementary phrase ("openness to experience"). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause, making the colon the better choice in this context. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause ("there...on") and the supplementary phrase ("openness to experience").

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dc645172

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: dc645172

The artistic talents of Barbara Chase-Riboud, most known for her 1979 historical novel *Sally Hemings* and the conversation it inspired, _____ limited to the realm of prose: she first excelled in sculpture, where her affinity for bronze—a material she described as “timeless” due to its use across eras and cultures—became part of her artistic identity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. hasn't been
- B. wasn't
- C. isn't
- D. aren't

ID: dc645172 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The subject "talents" is plural, and so is the verb "aren't": "the artistic talents...aren't limited."

Choice A is incorrect. The subject "talents" is plural, but the verb "hasn't been" is singular. Choice B is incorrect. The subject "talents" is plural, but the verb "wasn't" is singular. Choice C is incorrect. The subject "talents" is plural, but the verb "isn't" is singular.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6ea8c23f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 6ea8c23f

In 2018, a team of researchers led by Dr. Caitlin Whalen compiled every available measurement of ocean mixing rates from the past two decades. With this novel data set, the team was able to determine how current-driven mixing varies across _____ and what impact it has on the distribution of heat and nutrients in the ocean.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. regions,
- B. regions:
- C. regions;
- D. regions

ID: 6ea8c23f Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between coordinates in a sentence. The two elements "how...regions" and "what...ocean" work together as coordinates to complete the description of what the team was able to determine. Because there are only two coordinates in this case (as opposed to a series of three or more), no punctuation is needed between them.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinates "how...regions" and "what...ocean." Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinates "how...regions" and "what...ocean." Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinates "how...regions" and "what...ocean."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID aab74a3b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: aab74a3b

Researcher Lin Zhi developed a process for increasing the tensile strength—measured in gigapascals, or GPa—of silkworm ____ dissolving and reweaving the silk in a solution of iron metal ions, zinc, and sugar, Zhi increased the amount of force required to stretch it from approximately 0.5 GPa to 2 GPa.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. silk, by
- B. silk by
- C. silk and by
- D. silk. By

ID: aab74a3b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The independent clauses "researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving...2 GPa" can be grammatically separated by a period. They can stand alone as sentences, and this is the only choice that lets them do that.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. "Researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving...2 GPa" are both independent clauses. They need to either be separated with punctuation like a period or a semicolon, or they need to be connected by a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and." A comma alone isn't enough. Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a run-on sentence. "Researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving...2 GPa" are both independent clauses. They need to either be separated with punctuation like a period or a semicolon, or they need to be connected by a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and." Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a run-on sentence. "Researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving...2 GPa" are both independent clauses. The coordinating conjunction "and" isn't enough to link them by itself. We need a comma, too.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a9e5b788

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a9e5b788

In discussing Mary Shelley’s 1818 epistolary novel *Frankenstein*, literary theorist Gayatri Spivak directs the reader’s attention to the character of Margaret Saville. As Spivak points out, Saville is not the protagonist of Shelley’s _____ as the recipient of the letters that frame the book’s narrative, she’s the “occasion” of it.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. novel
- B. novel,
- C. novel; rather,
- D. novel, rather,

ID: a9e5b788 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a semicolon to join a main clause (“Saville...novel”) and a second main clause (“she’s...it”) preceded by supplementary elements (“rather...narrative”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, the comma after “novel” can’t be used in this way to join the two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d2b81427

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: d2b81427

In assessing the films of Japanese director Akira Kurosawa, _____ have missed his equally deep engagement with Japanese artistic traditions such as Noh theater.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. many critics have focused on Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources but
- B. Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources has been the focus of many critics, who
- C. there are many critics who have focused on Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources, but they
- D. the focus of many critics has been on Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources; they

ID: d2b81427 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “many critics” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “in assessing...Kurosawa.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that it is the critics—and not another noun in the sentence—who assess Kurosawa’s films.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Kurosawa’s...sources” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that his use of Western literary sources is what assesses Kurosawa’s films. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the function word “there” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that “there” is what assesses Kurosawa’s films. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the focus...critics” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the critics’ focus is what assesses Kurosawa’s films.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3bceeb93

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 3bceeb93

When they were first discovered in Australia in 1798, duck-billed, beaver-tailed platypuses so defied categorization that one scientist assigned them the name *Ornithorhynchus paradoxus*: “paradoxical bird-snout.” The animal, which lays eggs but also nurses _____ young with milk, has since been classified as belonging to the monotremes group.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. they’re
- B. their
- C. its
- D. it’s

ID: 3bceeb93 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The singular possessive pronoun "its" agrees with the singular antecedent "the animal" and indicates that the "young" belong to it.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a pronoun-antecedent agreement error. "They’re" is a contraction of "they are," a plural pronoun and verb, but the antecedent "the animal" is singular. Also, we don’t need the extra verb "are" — we already have a main verb in this clause, so adding "are" would be confusing and ungrammatical. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a pronoun-antecedent agreement error. "Their" is a plural pronoun, but the subject of the sentence is "the animal," a singular noun. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a confusing and ungrammatical sentence. "It’s" is a contraction for "it is." We already have the verb "nurses" in this clause, so we shouldn’t add the verb "is."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dab8b8ee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: dab8b8ee

Known as Earth’s “living skin,” biocrusts are thin layers of soil held together by surface-dwelling microorganisms such as fungi, lichens, and cyanobacteria. Fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. a recent study’s estimate is that these crusts reduce global dust emissions by 60 percent each year.
- B. an estimated 60 percent reduction in global dust emissions each year is due to these crusts, according to a recent study.
- C. these crusts reduce global dust emissions by an estimated 60 percent each year, according to a recent study.
- D. a recent study has estimated that these crusts reduce global dust emissions by 60 percent each year.

ID: dab8b8ee Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts." Subject-modifier placement requires a modifier and its subject to be next to each other, so "biocrusts" or some variant meaning "biocrusts" (in this case, "these crusts") must begin the missing clause.

Choice A is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts," not "a recent study’s estimate." Choice B is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts," not "an estimated 60 percent reduction." Choice D is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts," not "a recent study."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0fe5ce68

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 0fe5ce68

Ten of William Shakespeare’s plays are classified as histories. Although each one of these plays, which include *Henry V* and *Richard III*, _____ on a single historical figure (specifically, an English king), some, such as *Henry VI Part One* and *Henry VI Part Two*, feature different episodes from the same monarch’s life.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. focuses
- B. focus
- C. are focused
- D. were focused

ID: 0fe5ce68 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "focuses" agrees in number with the singular subject "each one of these plays," which refers to each play individually.

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "focus" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of these plays." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "are focused" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of these plays." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "were focused" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of these plays."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 790fc366

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 790fc366

Using satellite remote sensing, Dr. Catherine Nakalembe, director of NASA’s Harvest Africa initiative, gathers important data on crop health. Nakalembe doesn’t just compile the _____ she also shares her findings with African farmers, enabling them to make data-driven decisions about managing critical food crops.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. information, though;
- B. information, though,
- C. information; though
- D. information though,

ID: 790fc366 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice uses a semicolon to join two independent clauses ("Nakalembe doesn’t just... though" and "she also shares..."). This choice also appropriately includes "though" in the first clause, where it logically belongs.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. It incorrectly joins two independent clauses with only a comma instead of a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and" or "but." "Though" is a transition word, but it’s not a coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. A semicolon can only be used to link two independent clauses. However, if "though" is included in the second clause, it turns the second clause into a dependent clause, so a semicolon can’t be used after "information." Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. It incorrectly joins two independent clauses with only a comma instead of a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and" or "but."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 62120607

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 62120607

From afar, African American fiber artist Bisa Butler’s portraits look like paintings, their depictions of human faces, bodies, and clothing so intricate that it seems only a fine brush could have rendered them. When viewed up close, however, the portraits reveal themselves to be _____ stitching barely visible among the thousands of pieces of printed, microcut fabric.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. quilts, and the
- B. quilts, the
- C. quilts; the
- D. quilts. The

ID: 62120607 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“the portraits...quilts”) and the supplementary noun phrase (“the stitching...fabric”) that provides a further description of how the portraits can be identified as quilts.

Choice A is incorrect. A comma and the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “the stitching.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2bb7416a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 2bb7416a

In paleontology, the term “Elvis taxon” gets applied to a newly identified living species that was once presumed to be extinct. Like an Elvis impersonator who might bear a striking resemblance to the late musical icon Elvis Presley himself, an Elvis taxon is not the real thing, _____ is a misidentified look-alike.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. however but it
- B. however it
- C. however, it
- D. however. It

ID: 2bb7416a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so making them into two separate sentences is grammatically correct.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so they need to be separated with at least a comma + a coordinating conjunction. This choice provides the coordinating conjunction “but,” but it’s missing a comma. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so they need to be separated with a semicolon, a colon, a dash, a period, or a comma + a coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so they need to be separated with at least a comma + a coordinating conjunction. This choice provides a comma, but it’s missing a coordinating conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard